

Activated Charcoal

(Actidose with Sorbitol, Actidose-Aqua, Char-Flo with Sorbitol, EZ Char, Insta-Cahr, Insta-Char/Sorbitol, Kerr Insta-Char in Sorbitol, Kerr Insta-Char)

I. Classification – Antidote

II. Action(s)

- Absorbs toxic substances, thus inhibiting GI absorption and preventing or limiting systemic toxicity

III. Indication(s)

- As indicated by Poison Control or Medical Control physician
- Toxic ingestions of
 - Carbamazepine
 - Dapsone
 - Phenobarbital
 - Quinine
 - Theophylline
 - Caffeine
 - Acetylsalicylic acid
 - Phenytoin

IV. Contraindications

- Depressed mental status without airway protection (risk of aspiration)
- Late presentation
- Increased risk and severity of aspiration associated with activated charcoal use
- Need for endoscopy (activated charcoal will impair visibility during endoscopy)
- Toxins poorly absorbed by activated charcoal
- Presence of intestinal obstruction or concern for decreased peristalsis

V. Precautions

- Nausea and vomiting is common with activated charcoal
- The medication can be flavored as a slurry with a more palatable drink
 - Juice
 - Soda
 - Chocolate milk
 - Ice cream
- Sorbitol containing activated charcoal is not recommended in children due to electrolyte shifts

VI. Drug interactions

- Activated charcoal may decrease serum concentrations of many medications

VII. Adult Dosing and Administration

- Dose is optimally 10:1 (charcoal:poison) ratio
- 25-100g NG/OG/PO

VIII. Pediatric Dosing and Administration

- 0.5-1 g/kg (max dose 100g) PO/NG/OG

IX. Onset

- Unknown

X. Duration

- Unknown

XI. Possible Adverse Effects

- Aspiration
- Nausea and vomiting